PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep Wrangler Unlimited (LJ)

2004–2006 · LJ · TJ Unlimited

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Get under it with a flashlight and a hammer**
  Quadratec calls frame rot near the rear lower control-arm brackets 'the TJ issue'. The other early-rot zones are the transfer-case crossmember area and the central body mounts. A clean outside means nothing. Probe the inside of the rails and the arm brackets, and walk away from anything that's flaking through.
- [ ] **2005–06: ask about the OPDA**
  Late 4.0 engines can wear out the oil pump drive assembly. Owners describe the warning noise as a 'laughing monkey' squeal. Quadratec says that if there's no record of it being replaced or updated, deal with it proactively.
- [ ] **Is it a real Rubicon Unlimited?**
  Rubicons have a Dana 44 front axle, an NV241 Rock-Trac transfer case, air lockers and 4.10 gears. Check that both lockers engage, that 4-Low is the 4:1 Rock-Trac, and that a Sahara Edition has its numbered dash badge. Rubicon decals are cheap; Dana 44 fronts are not.
- [ ] **Drive it at 30–50 mph over bumps**
  OffroadXtreme suggests testing for death wobble in that speed range. A loose lower track-bar bolt, bent steering linkage, worn ball joints or tie-rod ends can all start it. On lifted examples, also check the rear track-bar bracket on the axle for cracks.
- [ ] **Look for leaks, and price them**
  The 4.0 commonly seeps from the rear main seal, oil pan, valve cover and oil-filter adapter gasket. Pinion and transfer-case output seals weep too. Mostly this is money rather than doom, but the rear main seal is a big job.
- [ ] **Check the radiator tanks**
  Factory TJ radiators have plastic end tanks crimped to an aluminum core. Quadratec says many start leaking at the upper seams around 100,000 miles. Look for green crust and a coolant smell.
- [ ] **Shift into 4-Low, twice**
  The factory 'Z-bar' transfer-case linkage pops out of worn plastic bushings, and the symptom is a Jeep that won't go into 4-Low. The bushings are cheap; a missed diagnosis is not.
- [ ] **Judge the modifications**
  A lifted LJ needs a longer or adjustable track bar, alignment correction and often a slip-yoke eliminator above 2 inches of lift. Ask who did the work, and inspect welds on frame repairs and brackets.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **42RLE park pawl anchor shaft**
  2005–2006 · NHTSA 05V460000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Six-speed clutch master cylinder rod**
  2006 · NHTSA 06V147000
- [ ] **Clutch pedal interlock switch**
  2006 · NHTSA 15V222000 (Chrysler R13)

- [ ] **VIN**
  In BaT-listed VINs we checked, an Unlimited reads 1J4FA44S... and an Unlimited Rubicon 1J4FA64S..., while short-wheelbase trucks have a 9 as the 7th character (1J4FA49S Sport, 1J4FA69S Rubicon). NHTSA's decoder doesn't reliably separate Unlimiteds from short-wheelbase trucks, so confirm with a tape measure: 103.4 in between the axle centers.
- [ ] **Wheelbase and length**
  103.4 in wheelbase against 93.4 in for a TJ, and about 167 in long to the bumper. The rear doors aren't there, but the long rear quarters and cargo area are hard to miss.
- [ ] **Rubicon hardware**
  Unlimited Rubicons have front and rear Dana 44s with lockers, the NV241OR (4:1 low range), diamond-plate rocker guards and 245/75R16 tires. Base Unlimiteds have a Dana 30 front, Dana 44 rear and the NV231 (2.72:1 low).
- [ ] **Sahara Edition**
  The 2005 Sahara Edition Unlimited Rubicon is Light Khaki with a numbered dash badge, chrome grille and Sahara spare-tire cover.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/tj-unlimited/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks